

The following oral history interview is the result of 1 videorecorded session of an interview with Brian Allen by Cynthia Tobar on February 22, 2018 in New York City. This interview is part of the Black Live Matter in Higher Education oral history project. Brian Allen has reviewed the transcript and has made minor corrections and emendations. The reader is asked to bear in mind that they/she/he is reading a verbatim transcript of the spoken word, rather than written prose.

Brian Allen

[Start of recorded material 00:00:00]

Brian: [00:00:01] Hello. My name is Brian Allan. I'm a first year doc student in the higher and post-secondary ed program. I work at NYU in the Center for Multicultural Education and Programs.

Interviewer: How long have you been at Teachers College?

Brian: [00:00:13] So this is my first year in the doc program, but I actually was a student in the master's program for two years. So this will be my third year here at TC.

Interviewer: How does your identity effect your experience as a student at TC?

Brian: [00:00:26] So I identify as a black queer cisgender man, male here at TC. I think searching for community has really informed a lot of my experience here. Being a master's student, I quickly joined the Black Student Network here which is an organization for black graduate students at TC. They help building community, providing professional development opportunities and just kind of coming together and finding that source of unity in an environment that doesn't necessarily cater to the needs of that particular community. So I think being a part of the higher ed program, having that background, really helped me see that that was something that was necessary. So yeah, I definitely think that the intersectional identities that I hold can be marginal in some ways but I often try to look at them as sources of liberation in terms of the community that does come by finding black-minded individuals and folks who share those identities.

Interviewer: How does your race effect your classroom experience at TC? Does it ever feel isolating?

Brian: [00:01:30] So first coming to TC, I would say yes. Imposter Syndrome is a very real thing. So I think just like not having many folks. And don't get me wrong, TC is becoming much more diverse than it was in prior years, and the higher ed program, in particular, is very diverse. If not the most diverse here at TC. So I think just going through the general qualms of not feeling inclined to participate in classroom experiences or feeling as though what I had to share

or my perspective wasn't valued or legitimate, I think those were some of the things I went through earlier on in my graduate career. But now I think I've kind of settled into the socialization identity of being a graduate student so it comes a little bit easier for me.

[00:02:18] So in a contemporary student issues course we were having a discussion about diversity and diverse student populations, specifically when it comes to race and ethnicity. And we were having conversations around allyship] and diversity and social justice. And in my second year, I think that I was a little bit more vocal in classroom discussions, and this is where I felt it was necessary to kind of throw nuance into the conversation around why allyship is important and there are certain ways that we can go about enacting allyship. For many folks in marginal communities, allyship doesn't exist. So thinking about how others offer support to different communities should be based in the needs and the wants of the community and not those who are searching to help. So I think I was a little cautious of sharing that information with the class but I think it was definitely something that was necessary. So it took a little bit more effort or oomph to share that with the class, being one of the only students of color in the classroom.

[00:03:17] Some students cried. Some pushed back. In that classroom that same evening, I had to inform one of my classmates as to why as a black man I can't benefit from reverse racism. So there was just a lot going on in that classroom but yeah.

Interviewer: Do you believe faculty and students value diversity at Teachers College?

Brian: [00:03:41] I think because TC is specifically a graduate school, it does value diversity more than other higher education institutions. I think just with the age being as though TC isn't mostly traditionally age students, and the fact that folks are a little bit more mature and advanced in their social justice understanding that folks, for the most part, are very much more appreciative and value diversity. I think the vice president's office for diversity and community affairs is a really great place for diversity issues and work that takes place here at TC and I think that's one of the main areas where support is provided in terms of scholarships, grants, just emotional well-being support and things like that.

[00:04:30] Janice and her staff really do a really good job at providing opportunities for students here. And if there ever are any issues or concerns that are raised, they do a pretty good at trying to field those questions, respond to those concerns rather than just sweeping them under the rug.

Interviewer: What are your recollections of your initial involvement with Black Lives Matter in higher education?

Brian: [00:04:49] So that was about two years ago. I was entering my second year as a master's student. We were reached out to by two faculty in the higher program: Dr. Noah Drezner and Dr. Corbin Campbell. Initially, they wanted to find ways to better position our program to show our support of the Black Lives Matter Movement nationally but then also to showcase the importance of diversity and social justice in the context of higher education. So Black Lives Matter in higher ed was an idea that came from three students, two faculty and really it was just a push for relating systemic issues surrounding white supremacy, anti-blackness, institutionalized racism and relating it specifically to higher education in the ways that it manifest in our field. So just having those conversations, whether it is seminars or lectures or roundtable discussions. They're really tackling those issues. They kind of discuss the ways that certain communities are pushed to the margins in higher education and aren't afforded the same level of access, opportunity or just well-being.

Interviewer: How is the organization and programmatic planning structured?

Brian: [00:06:07] So we actually just incorporated a planning community that involves more students, beyond the three students that initially were part of the founding of the organization. So there are about six new students who help us in terms of planning and executing programs, handling marketing and promoting, social media outreach and engagement. Things like that. But initially, it was just three students and the faculty who were kind of executing and planning all of these programs and ideas. And then we began to loop in more students who showed interest as we've progressed beyond our first year.

Interviewer: What was your vision of activism before becoming involved in Black Lives Matter in Higher Education? How has it changed?

Brian: [00:06:47] So I came from the University of Wisconsin, Madison which presented what I would consider a very chilly or hostile campus climate to their students of color, particularly the black students on their campus. So for me, I was a student activist on campus and I envisioned that being protesting, demonstrations, creating demands list, reaching out to executive leadership. So that's kind of the way that I viewed activism in terms of being very much in your face, calling out those types of things. I think throughout my graduate school experience and being a part of Black Lives Matter in higher education, that has changed. Or not necessarily has changed, but I've been introduced to more diverse ways of resisting and promoting justice and equity.

[00:07:42] So for me I think that activism has not evolved, but just become more open in terms of there are various ways and strategies that one can take in order to promote social justice inequity and I think that being in academia, taking the route of researching these issues, talking with folks who are directly impacted by these systems and just kind of advocating through different

means within the academy is a new way that I envision me taking on this work.

Interviewer: What do you see as the future of Black Lives Matter at TC?

Brian: [00:08:14] I think that a lot of students who are interested in these concepts or these conversations around social justice in higher ed so I think by presenting these topics around blackness in higher education, around free speech issues, around unemployment, around intersectionality, I think that that draws folks in who are either 1) interested and well-adept to these concepts or these conversations or topics and are looking for a deeper dive or folks who don't have any experience in these issues and are looking to gain some foundational knowledge. So I think that that interest will always be there. And there's always going to be an opportunity to bring students in which only amplifies our outreach and our ability to engage in more nuance conversation.

Interviewer: What are some of the highlights and challenges you've encountered during your two years working with Black Lives Matter at Teachers College?

Brian: [00:09:04] So far me, I think that one of my highlights was our first event. We had a roundtable discussion amongst higher ed, faculty, staff, students, around the campus protest at Missouri University when there was a student who was on a fast who wasn't eating because of the campus climate that the institution was facilitating. The football team was protesting and said that they weren't playing due to the campus environment. There were a lot of faculty who were disgruntled by the actions of the president. So we just had a genuine conversation around what our thoughts were on the issue in terms of how can higher education student affairs professionals better support students of color at predominantly white institutions.

[00:09:58] So we talked. We had guests from the White House at that event. David Johns, they shared their perspective in terms of education nationally and this new political climate. But it was a very uplifting, productive conversation around what can we do on the ground applicably to think about these concepts that we're talking about. And we talk about knowledge to practice gaps and there's research that says how you can ameliorate or improve campus environments but at the end of the day, that's not happening nationally. So what is it that we as folks who are studying this field do?

Interviewer: What impact has BLMHE had in terms of ameliorating issues associated with diversity at TC?

Brian: [00:10:41] Yeah, I think the folks are really excited the [#HIPC4BLM] is the hashtag that we use, exists here at TC. I'm thinking back to one event we had last year when we had presentations on Columbia Universities involvement in the Atlantic Slave Trade. And President Fuhrman, Susan Fuhrman, actually

gave an address at that event on a video call. She wasn't able to be there in person but I think just by her doing that and kind of being present at that event showed her investment in this issue and these topics. But I think across the board folk's turnout to events, they attend programs. I think there's just an eagerness to dive into social justice conversations because like I said earlier, either folks aren't understanding of these concepts or they have a foundational knowledge and are looking to explore more in terms of receiving information about what can we do tangibly to improve the experience of students here at TC, but across the board at other institutions.

[00:11:49] So our faculty are really involved in these events and programs. The students are very involved and are joining planning committees. And even staff come and have really good points and conversational questions that they pose to either facilitators or lecturers that we bring in. So I think that the interest is there. I think that folks see that the mission of the organization is something that is substantial or of importance to the community. I think that's really good.

Interviewer: What do you see as the future of Black Lives Matter at TC? And how will you be involved going forward?

Brian: [00:12:24] In the next year or so I see Black Lives Matter in higher education having more students involved in the planning process. I see it becoming more diverse and focusing not just on issues and concerns within the black community but across identity in terms of marginalization. I see students conducting research that is guided by faculty. I see us going to conferences. I see us presenting and I see this energy and this mission based on certain values and beliefs spreading to different institutions. So having the Black Lives Matter in higher education at different institutions and colleges and universities, not just TC as a graduate school.

Interviewer: Can you describe how Black Lives Matter in Higher Education has expanded beyond Teachers College?

Brian: [00:13:16] Honestly, Black Lives Matter in Higher Education is a very bold and unapologetic statement that I don't think many folks have made before. So when it comes to the tee shirt sales, I think in the first month or two we sold over 500 shirts or something like that. A ridiculous amount of shirts that just Black Lives Matter in Higher Ed. And throughout that semester, folks were wearing them to conferences, different retreats, they were wearing them in their offices, in classrooms. So folks were very excited to make that declaration that Black Lives Matter in Higher Ed or at their respective colleges or universities. I think the tee shirts were a really great addition to the programmatic efforts that we're making here at TC. And I think just getting people more invested in the conversation, in addition to the physical display of solidarity that tee shirts bring is really important as well.

Interviewer: How has your work with Black Lives Matter in Higher Education changed the way you engage in activism in your community?

Brian: [00:14:14] I think it's changed my perspective on callout culture. So thinking about folks who don't necessarily know terminology or understand the way the systems work or the way that folks become oppressed or how they navigate society. I think I've become much more able to call in folks in terms of you don't understand this so let me have this conversation or try to bring this information in a way that's a little bit more palatable to you so that it doesn't necessarily point blame or callout in terms of this is what you're doing wrong or saying wrong or you don't understand this. But rather saying these are the issues and this is what I know to be true and I know that you have another understanding of the way that the world works or the way that society works or the way that higher education works, but how do we come to an agreement in terms of you seeing my perspective and me using your perspective in order to help you better understand where we're coming from.

Interviewer: How could Black Lives Matter in Higher Education help provide support for issues that occur across other campuses? For example, NYU's offensive Black History Month dining hall menu?

Brian: [00:15:14] This is something that always come into question, at least since I've been an undergraduate student thinking about themed months in a variety of offices, and not just in cafeterias. But thinking about how can you be more intentional in involving either those who have that identity that you're looking to celebrate into the conversation around what can we do? Because I think that would better inform the direction that you took in celebrating Black History Month and the menu selection and all of that. I think these are the conversations that Black Lives Matter in Higher Ed seeks to highlight, is what are instances in which certain individuals feel excluded or silenced or directly discriminated against and what kind of directions can we take in order to better support those students and their experiences?

Interviewer: It's the 50th Anniversary of the Columbia Student Revolt of 1968. What are your thoughts about student activism's continued influence on culture and politics?

Brian: [00:16:09] I think that especially at Columbia University, I know that this has been a very politically active campus, whether it's students protesting, whether it's students creating demands and sending them to the president's office. I think that students very much inform the change that takes place at this university. But I think across the board students are the driving force for change in higher ed. So I think as long as students are given the opportunity to share their voice, there will always be opportunity for faculty, staff, executive

leadership to take up what is being said and figure out ways to implement change in the most productive and affective ways.

[00:16:54] So again, I see Black Lives Matter in Higher Education being one of those student-driven forces that can inform change here at the institution. I think that through collaboration with other student organizations, it only amplifies that effort so whether its students for quality education here at TC or the Black Student Network or Coalition of Latino Scholars, I think that everyone pretty much has the same vision in terms of an institution that supports all of its students and that brings their voice into the classroom and the curriculum and the readings that they're doing because representation is really important as well. So I think touching all of those bases and just kind of building coalitions or solidarity is what that speaks to.

[00:17:46] I think, if anything, it's kind of helped me sustain my energy in this work. I think coming from undergrad; I've gone straight through graduate school since undergrad so I think I've been invested in this work and just understanding what my rationale is behind staying in this work because it is exhausting in terms of trying to appeal to the moral senses of other folk. And it's like you can't really continue that for so long, and at some point, you just have to understand that this is the way that societies been structured, these are the systems that are in place. And whether you agree with it or not, this is what we know to be true and this is the work that needs to be done. So I think being a part of Black Lives Matter in Higher Ed has kind of affirmed that work and given me another outlet and a different method to addressing all of the needs and issues that I see on an everyday basis.

[End of recorded material 00:18:37]